

Middle East Weekly Review

September 13, 2026 (covering Monday September 7, 00:00 to Sunday September 13, morning, KST)

- **Week in brief:** The week Yemen's civil war stopped being a contained internal conflict and became the region's central strategic story, opening with Iran's own parliament declaring "proportionate responses" over, cresting midweek when the Houthis' war against Saudi Arabia's government allies spilled directly onto Saudi soil with a 73-wounded Aramco strike, and closing with the Houthis completing control of Yemen's entire Red Sea coastline, seizing Mocha and then the Bab el-Mandeb-dividing Perim Island in successive days even as government forces kept winning the interior war around Hays and Jawf. Alongside that, the direct US-Iran military track saw CENTCOM destroy eight Iranian tankers across two waves and Iran retaliate against Jordan's Azraq base a second time, while a fresh diplomatic rupture opened when the UK and eleven other countries banned trade with Israeli West Bank settlements and Israel closed its Jerusalem consulate in response. South Korea's own war exposure kept advancing procedurally without a decision, from a hardening domestic debate through a Paris cooperation agreement with France to a UAE fact-finding mission and a narrowed deployment package, while Trump's own rhetoric shifted from vague "ending soon" language to a specific, now twice-repeated post-midterms date. The ledger's own bookkeeping: 22 new indicators opened and 13 resolved, 6 confirmed against 7 falsified, a closer split than in recent weeks, before the war entered a genuine weekend lull that left every one of the week's sharpest open claims, Hegseth's Hormuz "control," the Houthis' shipping leverage, and Saudi Arabia's own request for direct US strikes, untested heading into Monday.
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1. The Week's Arc

What structurally changed this week is that Yemen's renewed civil war, which this ledger had tracked since early September as a serious but geographically contained conflict, became the war's most consequential front, first by threatening to reshape the regional balance through a direct Saudi strike, then by handing the Houthis uncontested control of the strait's western shore, a territorial fact no diplomatic or military development elsewhere this week matched in strategic weight.

Monday opened with rhetoric rather than action: Iran's parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf declared "the era of proportionate responses is over," threatening a "faster, heavier, more painful" response to any further US pressure, a declaration this ledger flagged as raising Tehran's own domestic political cost of responding with anything less than disproportionate force next time. The same day, Israel widened its south Lebanon campaign to four towns, killing at least seven and destroying a hospital and government ministry offices for a second time, prompting President Aoun's direct appeal to Washington, while Yemen's government captured the strategic Hays junction as the renewed war's four-day toll passed 117. President Lee departed for Paris as Korea's own deployment debate hardened along party lines in his absence.

Tuesday delivered Yemen's first shock: the confirmed toll nearly tripled to over 300 dead in roughly a day, the deadliest stretch since the 2022 truce, even as government forces held their gains and captured a further base in Jawf. Israel's Lebanon campaign widened further, a drone strike killing two medics and an airstrike destroying Nabatieh's Ghandour Hospital, the campaign's first hospital destroyed. Iran tested its own rhetoric only rhetorically, claiming an unconfirmed strike on an unmanned US vessel, while Korea's presidential office pushed back on reports of an imminent deployment motion and KOSPI, entirely decoupled from the war, surged 4.61% on a global chip rally.

Three long-tracked indicators resolved at their own deadlines: the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement falsified for a second time, and a mixed pair of settler-violence enforcement outcomes at Masafer Yatta (confirmed) and Jannatah (falsified).

Wednesday was the week's clearest escalatory threshold: Yemen's government declared an explicit goal of retaking Sanaa itself, and the Houthis answered not against Yemeni government forces but with a direct drone and missile barrage on Saudi Arabia's own Aramco facilities and King Khalid Air Base, wounding 73, the deepest the renewed war had cut into Saudi territory, drawing same-day Saudi retaliation on Taiz and Marib. Iran separately escalated its Hormuz narrative from an unconfirmed strike claim to a claimed capture of a US Navy underwater drone, which CENTCOM disputed as a recovered malfunction. In a second major thread, the UK broke sharply with Washington, banning trade with Israeli West Bank settlements alongside eleven other countries and formally calling the occupation unlawful, prompting Israel to close its Jerusalem consulate and bar twelve British MPs. For Korea, the day produced a concrete if limited deliverable: Presidents Lee and Macron agreed to cooperate on restoring Hormuz freedom of navigation, even as Seoul's presidential office repeated no deployment decision had been made. Five indicators resolved, two confirmed (Lee-Macron's cooperation agreement; CENTCOM's engagement with Iran's drone claim) and three falsified, as oil's climb toward \$100 finally broke KOSPI's week-long habit of ignoring Middle East risk.

Thursday sharpened Wednesday's picture into direct state-on-state confrontation: CENTCOM destroyed five more Iranian tankers after the IRGC twice failed to hit a US Navy warship, and Iran's answer landed not on that warship but on Jordan's Azraq air base for a second time this war, twenty missiles of which eighteen were intercepted. Iran did something rarer than escalate, producing the photographic evidence it had promised of the captured US drone, independently corroborated by naval analysts even as the capture-versus-malfunction dispute stayed unresolved. Yemen's Saudi-Houthi war widened further as a prison strike's toll rose to 23 and Riyadh vowed sustained strikes, while eight Arab and Muslim states backed the UK's settlement measure and Washington flatly refused to join. For Korea, the day supplied process: a joint assessment team dispatched to the UAE, with the prime minister and national security adviser both repeating nothing has been decided. Markets kept pricing the war's persistence, Brent breaking back above \$100 for the first time since May, KOSPI reclaiming 7,000 for the first time in 33 sessions, and President Trump conceding, unprompted, that the war will run past November's midterms rather than end "soon." Three indicators resolved, all confirmed: Ghalibaf's threatened harsher response (materialized as the Jordan strike), the Houthi-Saudi exchange's sustained combat role, and the drone-evidence indicator.

Friday delivered the week's most consequential single fact: Houthi forces captured the Red Sea port of Mocha, a position Saudi-backed government forces had defended just days earlier, even as those same government forces kept winning ground in the north, a war splitting into two fronts with opposite outcomes on the same day Pakistan warned that continued Houthi strikes on Saudi Arabia could reactivate the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement it had already watched lapse once. Israel opened a second pressure front, detonating over 1,100 tons of explosives to destroy a Hezbollah tunnel complex on Ali Taher Ridge, a blast registering as a magnitude-4.1 earthquake, days before the next round of Rome-brokered Israel-Lebanon talks. Oil's confirmed Wednesday settle, arriving a day late, broke \$101 for the first time since May, and Trump repeated in Dallas that the war ends "immediately after" the midterms. Korea's UAE assessment team returned with a narrowed package, a P-8A patrol aircraft and EOD teams rather than the logistics ship requiring over a hundred sailors, while Jordan's response to its second Azraq strike stayed limited to an interception count, an analysis attributing the restraint to deep structural dependence on Washington. No indicator resolved.

The weekend delivered the week's structurally biggest fact and then, immediately, its quietest stretch. Saturday, the Houthis completed what Friday began: capturing Perim (Mayun) Island, the volcano that divides Bab el-Mandeb itself, giving them uncontested control of both shores of the strait's narrowest crossing for the first time in this war,

even as Trump and Hegseth used the Pentagon's 25th-anniversary September 11 commemoration to fold the Iran war into a war-on-terror narrative, Hegseth declaring "we control the Strait" of Hormuz in the same week Iran claimed its heaviest wave of shipping attacks yet. Oil retreated from the week's sharpest rally as Iran agreed to Oman-hosted Salalah talks with Gulf states, and the ledger resolved two long-tracked indicators falsified on the same day, Syria's Assad-era nuclear file (closed diplomatically without verified physical removal) and the West Bank's IDF-to-police enforcement transfer (no incident decline). Sunday then produced the week's quietest day by design rather than accident: no new incident tested any of the week's sharpest claims, Trump repeated the midterms prediction from Ireland while adding an unverified claim about a Saudi pipeline attack, and a single war-tracker report surfaced that Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman had twice asked Trump for direct US strikes on the Houthis and been turned down, a data point on the limits of US appetite for a third military front even as a close Gulf ally absorbed the week's biggest strategic loss.

Three shifts to carry forward. First, Yemen's civil war is no longer a contained secondary front; it is now the week's central strategic story. The sequence from Hays's capture through the Aramco strike to Mocha and Perim's fall means Yemen now drives regional escalation risk as directly as Hormuz itself, with the Houthis holding a chokepoint whose shipping-side consequences (IND-20260912-1) remain the single most consequential untested question heading into next week. **Second, the war's rhetoric-to-action gap widened rather than closed.** Ghalibaf's threatened harsher response did eventually materialize (the Jordan strike), but Hegseth's "control" claim, Trump's midterms prediction, and now the Saudi pipeline accusation all sit as asserted facts this ledger cannot yet verify, a pattern of senior officials on multiple sides making claims that outrun the confirmable evidence. **Third, Korea's Hormuz process kept advancing without ever crossing into decision, and this week's weekend revelation, that even Saudi Arabia's own crown prince cannot secure direct US strikes, is a data point Seoul's planners should weigh: Washington's appetite for expanding its own military footprint is visibly limited even for its closest regional partners, a relevant caution against assuming a Korean contribution would materially change US risk tolerance in the Gulf.**

2. Indicator Scoreboard

Opened this week: 22. Four Monday, three each Tuesday through Thursday, four Friday, three Saturday, two Sunday.

Resolved this week: 13 — 6 Confirmed, 7 Falsified.

Resolved	ID	Outcome	What it settled
09-08	IND-20260809-2	Falsified	The Mecca Joint Defence Agreement produced no concrete implementing step a month after signing
09-08	IND-20260825-2	Confirmed	A second separate settler arrest (Qusra) met the Masafer Yatta enforcement pattern's bar
09-08	IND-20260826-2	Falsified	No arrest ever followed the Jannatah settler-violence case despite strong video evidence
09-09	IND-20260822-1	Falsified	Saudi restraint after a smaller August claim was superseded by the far larger Sept 8 Aramco attack
09-09	IND-20260902-2	Falsified	Trump's threatened "biggest attack of them all" on Iranian territory never materialized
09-09	IND-20260903-2	Falsified	No further Iranian strike on Jordan, Bahrain, Iraq or Kuwait followed the Sept 1-2 threats in that window
09-09	IND-20260907-3	Confirmed	The Lee-Macron summit produced a concrete Hormuz cooperation agreement
09-09	IND-20260908-2	Confirmed	CENTCOM's malfunction statement resolved whether Iran's unmanned-vessel claim would draw a US response
09-10	IND-20260907-1	Confirmed	Ghalibaf's threatened harsher response materialized as the Jordan Azraq missile strike
09-10	IND-20260909-1	Confirmed	The Houthis' overnight barrage across four provinces met the bar for a sustained direct Saudi combat role
09-10	IND-20260909-2	Confirmed	Iran's promised photographic and video evidence of the captured drone surfaced and was independently corroborated
09-12	IND-20260812-2	Falsified	Syria's nuclear file closed diplomatically without verified physical removal of the uranium
09-12	IND-20260815-2	Falsified	West Bank settler violence continued at a record pace despite the IDF-to-police enforcement transfer

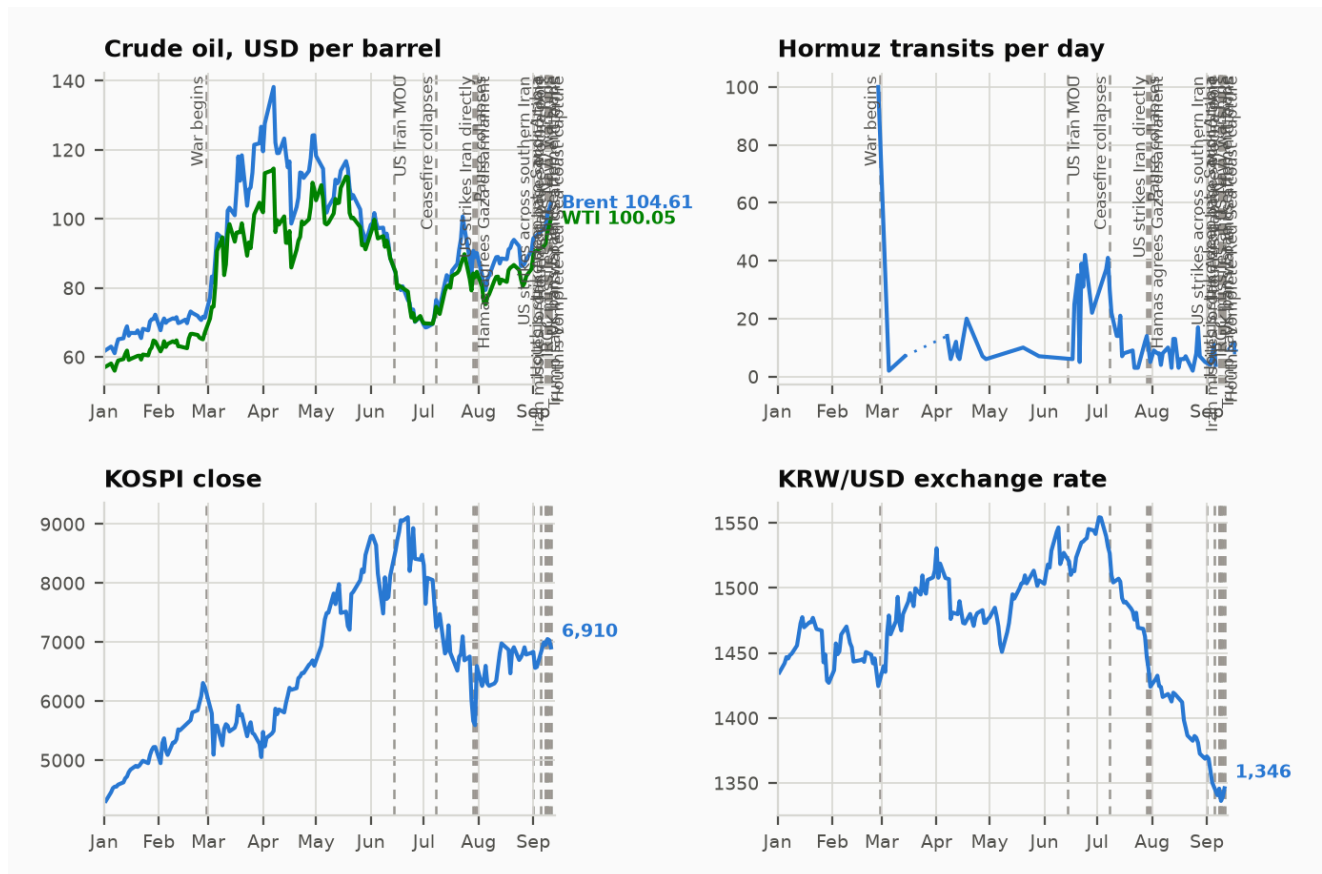
Still open: 33, including all indicators opened this weekend (IND-20260913-1 on Trump's unverified Saudi pipeline claim; IND-20260913-2 on whether Saudi Arabia escalates unilaterally after its declined strike request) alongside the week's most consequential untested claims: whether the Houthis' completed Bab el-Mandeb capture produces a verified shipping incident (IND-20260912-1), whether Hegseth's Hormuz "control" claim holds (IND-20260912-3), and whether Monday's Salalah talks actually convene (IND-20260912-2).

Calibration notes. Two lessons this week actually taught.

The falsification-leaning base rate held again but by a narrower margin than last week's 25-to-8 split: 7 falsified against 6 confirmed this week, the closest split in recent memory. The difference is that several of this week's confirmations were not simply "conflict continues" claims but specific institutional actions that did materialize on schedule, the Lee-Macron cooperation agreement, CENTCOM's engagement with Iran's drone claim, and Iran's delivery of promised photographic evidence, suggesting the base rate toward falsification is strongest for claims of restraint or de-escalation and weaker for claims that a specific, already-in-motion diplomatic or evidentiary process will complete.

The second lesson concerns data gaps rather than resolutions: Hormuz transit counts went entirely unreported for a full calendar week, the longest such gap this ledger has recorded, even as the strait's western approach changed hands entirely. A ledger that tracks chokepoint risk cannot let its own transit-count series go dark for a week without flagging the gap itself as a finding; future runs should treat a week-long absence of any Kpler or Windward print as noteworthy in its own right, not merely as a blank cell.

3. Data Trends



Oil. Brent ran \$97.05 (Mon, intraday, Labor Day) → \$97.99 (Tue, intraday) → \$101.21 (Wed, confirmed settle, its first close above \$100 since May) → no corroborated settle (Thu) → \$104.61 (Fri, confirmed, though down 2.8% on the day as Iran's Salalah talks agreement read as de-escalatory), a net gain of roughly 9.2% from last Friday's \$95.80, driven almost entirely by the Wednesday Aramco attack and Thursday's Jordan strike, with Friday's pullback the week's only reversal. WTI tracked the same path, \$92.10 to \$100.05, a 9.7% weekly gain. No settle exists for Saturday or Sunday, consistent with this ledger's practice of not inventing weekend prints, though Trump's Saturday prediction that prices will "come down sharply" once the war ends is itself untested against Monday's reopening.

Korea's markets spent the week testing, then losing, their decoupling from Middle East risk. KOSPI ran 6,995.39 (Mon, +4.61% on an AI/chip rally unrelated to the war) → 6,954.52 (Tue, -0.58%) → 7,051.64 (Wed, +1.40%, briefly clearing 7,000 as oil's climb toward \$100 finally moved Korean equities) → 7,033.92 (Thu, -0.25%) → 6,909.91 (Fri, -1.76%, its sharpest single-day drop of the week as the war's news flow accelerated), a net -1.2% for the week that masks a clear pattern: the two days Middle East risk demonstrably drove the tape (Wednesday's Aramco shock and Friday's Bab el-Mandeb and Pentagon news) were also the week's two negative-to-mixed sessions, while the AI rally drove Monday's gain independent of the war entirely. The won firmed modestly from

1,350.4 to 1,345.9, a net 0.3% gain, holding closer to flat than the equity swings, consistent with prior weeks' pattern of the currency and equity channels responding to different inputs.

Hormuz. No transit count was reported for any date this week, the first full calendar week with zero dated Kpler or Windward prints in this ledger's run, even as the strait's western approach at Bab el-Mandeb changed hands entirely and Hegseth publicly claimed the US "controls" the strait. This is itself a data point: a week in which the chokepoint narrative moved the most (in claims, if not yet in verified transits) is also the week this ledger's own transit-count series went completely dark.

What the chart does not show. Yemen's toll passing 300 dead, the Houthis' capture of Mocha and then Perim Island, the UK-Israel diplomatic rupture, Korea's UAE assessment team and narrowed deployment package, Hegseth's Hormuz claim, and the weekend's MBS-Trump phone calls all fall on days the trading week either does not cover or cannot yet price. For the seventh consecutive week, several of this review's most structurally consequential developments landed on a Saturday or Sunday, this week's largest event, the completed capture of the entire Red Sea coastline, chief among them.

4. Slow Threads

- **Hormuz transit counts, now entirely unreported for a full week.** Neither Kpler nor Windward produced a single dated print, the longest data gap this ledger has recorded on its own core chokepoint metric.
 - **Pickaxe Mountain, still unstruck nine days past Trump's "very soon" threat** (IND-20260905-1, ~09-18).
 - **Ben Gvir's Disengagement 710 plan, still with no confirmed host country interest** ten days after unveiling (IND-20260904-2, ~09-18).
 - **Qatari LNG loadings at Ras Laffan, this ledger's longest-running unresolved indicator,** still with no fresh weekly figure (IND-20260714-4).
 - **Syria's warned military move against Hezbollah in Lebanon** (IND-20260815-3, ~09-15, two days out), still untested either way.
 - **The internal Pentagon warning that a prolonged Iran campaign is unsustainable** (IND-20260831-2, ~09-14, one day out), with operations if anything intensifying rather than drawing down since the warning surfaced.
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5. Revisions and Lessons

What changed about standing assumptions.

Yemen's civil war has graduated from a tracked secondary front to the war's primary strategic story, and this ledger's categorization should reflect that going forward. Until this week, Yemen coverage sat alongside Lebanon and the West Bank as one of several fronts orbiting the central US-Iran and Hormuz narrative. The sequence from Hays through the Aramco strike to Mocha and Perim's fall means the Houthis now hold direct chokepoint leverage comparable to Iran's own Hormuz position, and future briefs should weight Yemen developments accordingly rather than as a subsidiary thread.

The gap between senior officials' asserted claims and verifiable evidence widened this week rather than narrowed, and this ledger's indicator-writing should treat that gap itself as the pattern worth tracking. Hegseth's "control" claim, Trump's repeated midterms prediction, Iran's escalating drone narrative (strike, then capture, then evidence),

and now the unverified Saudi pipeline accusation are all claims from senior officials on different sides that this ledger opened indicators to test rather than accepting at face value; the fact that several already sit unresolved or only partially verified is itself evidence that this war's information environment is becoming less, not more, reliable as it lengthens.

Korea's Hormuz calculus gained a genuinely new data point this week: Washington's own reluctance to expand its military footprint, tested against its closest Gulf ally's direct request, not just against Seoul's own domestic hesitation. If a single war-tracker report proves accurate that MBS himself was turned down twice, that is more informative for Seoul's planners than months of Korean domestic debate alone, since it suggests the constraint on any Korean contribution's strategic value may lie as much in Washington's own risk appetite as in Korea's.

The lesson from the week's structure. For the seventh consecutive week, this review's most structurally consequential development, the completed capture of Yemen's entire Red Sea coastline, happened on a weekend the standard trading week cannot price until Monday. This ledger's practice of publishing full daily editions on weekends remains the only reason this review can report Saturday's Perim Island capture and the Pentagon's Hormuz claim, and Sunday's MBS-Trump revelation, on the dates they actually happened rather than folded belatedly into Monday's edition after markets have already begun repricing around them.